

“Leopardia”

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There'd been rumors of the leopard. A large black dangerous thing stalking neighbors' yards. A teenage couple, making out in the boy's coupe parked in his driveway, saw the leopard lurking among the rosebushes. Days later, the boy's mother spotted the tracks. Heavy indentations marked the pad of the foot, and when she leaned closer, she could see the imprint of the claws. Her eyes followed the trail of the animal through the moist earth. Later, her husband would call her foolish, believing that the tracks could have been any old animal, and he scoffed when she insisted on calling the police.

The next morning, a few houses down, a little girl screamed from her bedroom. When her parents came, she pointed to the windowpane streaked with mud. In stuttered phrases, she told them of the leopard—its black fur, shiny and dark, and how it moved stealthily across the lawn, unafraid and with its yellow eyes gleaming. The parents hushed their child, calming her fear, and when the tender pulse of her heart slowed, they quickly forgot to ponder over whether or not what their daughter had told them was true. A leopard? Surely not, they thought.

Then an elderly man, perhaps senile, witnessed the leopard sitting lackadaisically on his front porch. He watched as it licked its fur clean with its pinkish tongue before turning on its back and stretching out on the floor. Wanting to scare it off, he went and found his BB gun. Aiming through his window, he shot at it a few times but missed. He told reporters that because of his cataracts, he wasn't sure if he hit the leopard or just scared it off, but “The thing ran like hellfire, so I suppose my BBs did the job.” When asked if maybe because of his cataracts he'd seen something else entirely—a large cat perhaps—he snuffed and said, “Believe what you believe, but what I saw was no house cat.”

Not knowing if the stories were real or fake, parents erred on the side of caution, locking up their children inside their homes to make sure none of them became a snack.

Billy had been one of the first to see the leopard. One night, weeks before, he couldn't sleep. With his twelfth birthday coming up, he felt he was old enough to stay up past nine o'clock, but his mother felt otherwise and enforced a strict bedtime. A little after midnight, he'd woken up and snuck down the hall to the living room to watch late-night sitcom reruns. He was coming from the kitchen, where he had stopped to get a glass of milk, when he glanced out the window. There was the leopard. He watched it stalking across the grass, the porch lights illuminating the sheen of its dark fur. It turned its head to face him, and he stared into its eyes. Billy dropped his glass, and it shattered across the wooden floor, the milk splashing against his bare feet. Billy looked down at the mess he'd made, and when he turned toward the window again, the leopard was gone.

His mother, woken by the noise, came to find her son kneeling down on the floor, mopping up milk with a dishrag. When Billy saw her, noticing the wrinkled server outfit she'd fallen asleep in, her hair loosely disheveled, eyeliner smeared, he wanted to cry.

"I'm sorry I woke you," he said.

His mother smiled. She went and got a bathroom towel and dropped it on the floor. "It's okay. Let's leave the rest," she said. She put a hand on his shoulder and followed him back upstairs.

Billy couldn't bring himself to tell his mother about the leopard. A few weeks before, his teacher had called his mother into school to talk about his behavior—about the lies, as she called them, the imaginings that occupied not just his thoughts but his conversations with the other students. Billy liked to tell stories, starting a little over a year ago.

His father had taken him to the toy store and said to pick out whatever he wanted. What Billy wanted was an electric train set, complete with over a hundred square feet of tracks. A model was on display at the front of the store, the last set left, and Billy had pointed to the train as it choo-chooed by. His father didn't even blink in hesitation, ordering the clerk to take the model and box it up for his son. But when the time came for him to pay at the register, after he'd given the clerk his card and then a second one, each returned back with a smirk, his father had finally sighed, leaned down to face his son, and said "Hey, how about we go and find something else?"

They eventually settled on a costume box found in the bargain bin. The box included several props for pretend play—a plastic stethoscope and thermometer for a doctor; a sword, eye patch, and telescope for a pirate; a microphone; a bow and arrow. Billy took the box home, and in his room he made up characters with each of the props. With the bow and arrow, he was Eduardo the marksman. With the sword, he became Captain Willowby of the ship *The Plunderer's Dream*. With the sword, he was Dr. Zhivago, the name taken from his mother's favorite film. Throughout the night, Billy created their stories, and the next day, after his father had gone for good, he found that he was more content in the worlds he created rather than the one he lived in.

When his mother found out what had happened at the toy store, she took him back and, using all the money she'd made that day, bought the train set. She let him build it in their living room. They sat on the floor eating peanut-butter sandwiches and licking their fingers as the train glided around and around.

“You know what the difference is between a lie and the truth, right?” his mother had asked during the car ride home. Earlier that afternoon, she’d received a call from his teacher to meet with her after school.

The teacher had assigned Billy’s class to write about something that had happened to them during the previous week. Afterward, they were supposed to share with the class what they wrote. Billy wrote about the leopard. He told everyone that he was the first to see it outside his house. He described how it looked and told them how he was going to catch it and train it to be his pet.

“See, I’m the one who finds animals,” Billy told his teacher. “I’m a hunter.”

His teacher had given a long, hard sigh before turning to the rest of the class. She was about to call on another student when one of the kids, a large pimply boy who made up for his appearance by being aggressively mean, interrupted and called Billy a liar in front of the class. Billy had ignored it until the boy started chanting “Liar, liar, pants on fire.” The other students soon followed. Billy, through budding tears, got up and punched the boy in the face.

“A lie is not the truth,” Billy had answered his mother as she drove.

“Yes, and the story you told in class—which is it?”

She’d left her office job early to make it to the school. She still wore her blouse and slacks, but the blouse was untucked and the bottom buttons undone. Her restaurant uniform, unwashed, was thrown in the backseat of the car.

“It was a lie.”

“That’s right. A lie. You’re not a hunter or a magician or any one of those other things you pretend to be. You can’t keep doing this, you know. You can’t tell people things that aren’t true and expect them to believe it.”

Billy thought about what she was saying. “Where’d Dad go?”

For the past year, his mother had told him different versions of the same story—that his father couldn’t handle the life he’d made for himself, that he was a good man who made bad choices, that he acted poorly but meant well—stories with nothing of substance for Billy to hold on to. His father had left on a Friday afternoon. Billy had come home to find an envelope addressed to his mother on the kitchen table. He’d waited until his mother was home to tell her. Her fingers had paused over the unbroken seal before opening it. Inside the envelope was a letter folded around a check. She read both before stuffing them back inside and tucking the envelope in her pocket. She didn’t tell Billy what they said.

Billy’d seen the separation papers, though. His mother had fallen asleep one night in the living room after reading them. A bottle of chardonnay had spilled on the scattered papers that sat crinkled on the coffee table. Billy went to clean up the mess, picking up each of the pages and stacking them into a neat pile for his mother. He read the words but didn’t really understand them, words like “alimony” and “dissolution.”

“He’s just gone,” she said now, which was what she’d told him the day he left. “That’s the only story I know to be true.”

She turned into the roundabout and at the third exit made a right onto the road that led home. Billy’s house was one of several single-family Craftsman-style houses in a subdivision in the northeast part of town, valued for its close proximity to Marshford’s Lake. Great care was taken with these homes to make them look effortlessly perfect. Almost everyone shared the same landscaper, causing the houses to have a coordinated look. Conformity was mandated by the homeowners’ association. Rules included having a consistently sodded lawn, using zoysia grass no more than two inches high, not having any unapproved lawn decorations, including pink flamingos,

flag poles, garden gnomes, or statues of any kind. Cars were prohibited from being parked on the side of the road. Doing so could result in towing at the owner's expense. And each home must be well-kept and maintained to the standards of its original purchase price.

"They try to pay for the life they think they want, even while deep down knowing they can never afford it," Billy's father had told him once. He'd been able to buy one of the homes because he'd been a contractor for the subdivision. Then the market turned, and he lost business. Before he left, they'd been three months behind on their mortgage.

In order to keep up the house payments, his mother worked two jobs. During the day she worked as a senior accountant for a health-care company, and four nights a week she worked at a Denny's diner—two towns over so no one she knew would ever see her. Mornings, Billy would come downstairs to find Styrofoam boxes full of greasy Grand Slams that they'd eat together before he went off to school. That was usually the only time he ever saw her, except for moments like now as they both sat in the car, Billy crouched down low and small in the passenger seat while his mother, both hands gripping the steering wheel, tried not to raise her voice.

"Don't make all this harder," she said as she pulled into their driveway. Billy knew what she meant. If he kept it up, his teacher would talk to the principal, and there'd be another meeting to discuss his home life. With enough questions, they'd learn about how much his mother worked, how often she left Billy home alone, and her parenting would be called into question. "Can't you just be good?" she asked, her eyes pleading for him to agree.



"Nightly Terror Prowling Neighbors' Backyards!" the headline of the *Daily Courier* said. And "Leopard in Suburbia!" The local TV station took it one step further, the anchor shortening it to

“Leopardia!” For years reporters had covered issues like a new organic supermarket opening or a change in a traffic ordinance. Now there was actual news projected onto the television screen—a leopard, sleek and hunting. The camera cut to images of half-eaten rabbit carcasses left discarded on otherwise pristine lawns as the reporter emphasized words like “fear” and “safety.” They referenced other incidents when animals had run loose among city streets. In Florida, a man shot and killed a bear that had wandered onto his property. In Ohio, two tigers were killed in a similar incident.

The theory was that the leopard had gone missing from the nearby Pepperdine Public Zoo. The leopard was one of several rare species meant to be part of a new exhibit on near-extinct animals. The escape had been part of a protest over “the great injustice of caging them for public consumption.” It was not a stretch of the imagination to believe this, especially considering how it was only a few years ago when one of the zoo attendants attempted to free one of the lions to protest against the zoo’s labor laws. His plan had backfired, however, when in the process the lion attacked him. What wasn’t eaten of his internal organs had been dispersed across the floor of the zoo’s café. Understandably, the incident had caused a sharp decline in ticket sales, so when word spread that a leopard was running rampant in the suburbs, the zoo made sure to let the public know that it was not their doing.

Billy watched the reports and imagined himself in the deepest reaches of the jungle. His father was there with him, both of them hunters of exotic animals. The bow and arrow was Billy’s weapon of choice, while his father carried a long spear to stab the heart of any enemy who got in their way. Whereas other hunters wanted the leopard as a trophy, which they’d skin and stuff for their living room, or sell its parts on the black market—its pelt for rugs or clothes, its claws and canine teeth for trinkets or trophies, its bones crushed to powder for medicine—Billy and his father wanted instead to save the leopard, and so they would take the other men down with no regret.

He began dreaming of his adventures, and often his father was with him in his dreams. They led a team on a quest through the African jungle. While crossing a river, they noticed crocodiles in the water. Billy, being faster than his father, managed to swim to land first. When Billy looked back, he caught one of the crocodiles snapping his father's body in half before slowly sinking down in the river gulf.

The specifics of the dream were always different—they took different paths, they were looking for other animals, they were coming back from the hunt instead of on it—but the outcome was always the same. He always heard the sound of his father's bones crushing.

Billy tried tucking away the dreams and instead focusing his thoughts on finding the leopard. After capturing it, he'd become its owner, taking care of it by feeding it cans of corned beef and salmon he'd salvaged from the pantry. It wouldn't matter if no one else believed him. The leopard would be his, and it would never leave.



In order to find the leopard, Billy first had to decide where it could have gone. It'd been a week since he'd mentioned the leopard, believing that he'd have to find it to convince his mother he was telling the truth. That weekend while his mother was at work, he went and found a map of the town that his mother kept in the study. He unfolded it across the kitchen table, spreading his hands flat against it to smooth out the paper.

Where would a leopard go in suburbia? Places where it was cool and there was water. Billy looked at the map. With a pencil he circled all the homes where spottings had been reported. He discovered that they formed a pattern. Not only were they all focused on a certain area, but Billy was

able to pinpoint the route of the leopard, tracing its trail to where he believed it was now. There was a park a mile west of his home, and he suspected that's where the leopard had gone.

Outside, neighbors had tacked up neon-colored flyers with words like "Caution" and "Danger" bolded across the top. Billy noticed the images first. Because no one had managed to take a picture of the leopard, the flyers all contained stock photos, only a few were wrong. Billy caught a picture of a cheetah on one, a tiger on another. The flyers were everywhere—plastered on front doors, tucked between windshield wipers, and stapled to all the trees in front yards that homeowners would allow.

Billy ripped one of the flyers off a tree. On this one, bolded below the image someone had marked the word "Reward" in black marker, leaving their number below that.



In the jungle, you have to move smoothly, slowly, and with purpose. You need to use a machete to cut through the dense vegetation instead of grasping with your hands, and learn to be part of your surroundings, using your body so that it blends in among the thick undergrowth. You want to be invisible, not just to what you hunt but to what is hunting you—animals, law enforcement, other hunters looking to cut out the competition.

Billy told himself these things as he made his way through the park. It was early in the afternoon, and families were still picnicking at tables. He glanced at them but quickly walked past, afraid that if he stopped they'd notice him walking alone and ask questions. He found one of the hiking trails and disappeared into the woods.

Billy was grateful he didn't have to cut through trees with a machete. Using his hands was enough to pull away any branches that blocked his view. Once he was deep enough in the woods to

be alone, he sat on the ground and pulled out his map. His goal was to head toward the lake where he believed he'd find the leopard, and the lake was a twenty-minute walk. He folded the map and continued on.

At first it was fun. Billy peed in the bushes. He ate trail mix and energy bars he'd packed in his book bag. He went to the edge of the lake to fill an empty water bottle but then decided against drinking from it. The closer time crept to dusk the more unsettled he became. Every movement put him on edge. He thought he saw the leopard several times, but when he looked, he'd find a deer grazing or a flock of birds landing on some tree branches.

He gave up. With his map spread out in front of him, he sat on the ground and tried to get his bearings, but after a few minutes of staring at the map, he realized he had no idea where he was. The mix of panic and fear caused his skin to flush red. He tried to keep from crying, but faced with the loneliness of the woods, he couldn't help himself.

"Hey, hey, you okay there?" Billy heard a voice call. He saw a man come out of the trees. He was dressed in a T-shirt, cutoff jeans, and a wide-brimmed hat. His black hair was long and wiry, like dark coils springing from his face. He wore square, thick-rimmed glasses that he kept having to push up the bridge of his nose. "What are you doing out here?" he said.

"I was trying to find the leopard," Billy choked out. "I thought it was out here."

"You lost?"

"No," Billy said. "Yes."

“I got a phone in my trailer. Come with me and you can call your folks from there if you want.” He started walking. After a few steps, he turned back around. “Well, come on now,” he shouted, and Billy hesitantly gathered his map and followed.

His trailer was a few yards down the path, parked down in the brush. A foldout chair was sitting in the grass in front as well as an opened cooler. A few crushed beer cans were scattered in the grass. The man picked them up before opening the door of the trailer.

The inside of the trailer was a mess. Black-and-white pictures of indiscernible objects were taped all over the walls. It looked as if the man had been living in the trailer for weeks and would continue to for longer. He had a water tank next to cans of food stacked in a pile. Opened leftovers of corned beef sat on the kitchen table, the smell of which managed to fill the whole room. He appeared not to notice.

“Here. Sit. I’ll make you some tea and then tell you where you are.” He shuffled back and forth in the tight space, quickly, sporadically. His feet moved through the crumpled remains of newspapers scattered across the floor. He found a mug, which he wiped down with a wet paper towel before placing it in front of him. “After I get this settled, then we can both look at your map. You can call your folks if you want or I can drive you where you need to go. Now, tea bags. Let’s see.”

“It’s okay. I’m not thirsty,” Billy said.

The man frowned. “You sure?”

Billy nodded, and the man shrugged before sitting down. “My name’s Marty. So you said you were trying to find something?”

Billy pulled the leftover flyer from his pocket and handed it to man. “Hrumph,” he said as he read the caption. His eyes narrowed. “You after this reward money?”

“No. I wanted to keep the leopard,” Billy said. “I was going to train it.”

“Like the circus?”

Billy hadn’t thought about that before, but he told him yes, like the circus. Marty nodded and then folded the paper back up. “You know they abuse those animals in the circus, don’t you?”

“What?”

“I saw it on television. How did you think they get them to do all those tricks? They beat them, starve them, do all kinds of horrible things. You think the animals want to be there? Balancing balls on their nose and jumping through hoops?”

Marty’s fingers fondled the edges of the flyer. Billy thought about asking for it back but decided against it. He looked around the walls of the trailer, at the photographs and drawings and maps.

“What is all this?” Billy said, changing the subject. He pointed to one of the images—a black-and-white photo of a girl, a teenager. “Who is that there?”

“My daughter Jennie,” Marty said. “That’s why I’m here. I’ve been trying to find her.”

“What happened?”

“If you ask the police, they’ll tell you she’s a runaway. The police think she took off with her no-good boyfriend, but I know my girl. She had a happy life. Not perfect, but happy. I know she wouldn’t do what the police keep saying. She wouldn’t leave me like that. With no word, no nothing.”

“Why do you think she’s here?”

“I read in the paper about how they’d found”—he paused, rubbed his lips together, and continued—“I just think she’s here, is all. So I’m going through every piece of the park. This map here shows all the ground I’ve covered, see? It’s only been a few weeks, but I’m making progress.”

Marty had shaded with a marker the parts of the park he’d been to. It wasn’t much, just a fraction of what he needed to finish. “You still have a lot left to go through,” Billy said as he nodded toward the map. “What if you don’t find her?”

“I’ll find her.”

“But what if she’s not here? What if she really did leave with her boyfriend?”

“You disappoint me, kid,” Marty said. “Here, look.”

Marty handed him a ripped piece of one of the clippings. There wasn’t much left, just a fragment of paper. Billy scanned the headline, pausing at the words “bodies” and “girls.”

“How far would you go?” Marty asked, taking the clipping back.

“Go? For what?”

“What do you think? To find this leopard, I mean. You’re out here too, aren’t you? So how far would you go?”

“I don’t know.”

“That’s the question, isn’t it? The one we ask ourselves. I’ve asked myself many times. How far? How much? How long? Well, this is my daughter we’re talking about, and I guess the answer is I’m here.”

“I wish I could find it,” Billy said. “I told everyone I would, and if I don’t, it’s like I failed.”

“Hey, at least you’re trying, right? Isn’t that what matters?”

Marty gave a weak smile. Billy held on to Marty’s question, turning it around in his head.

“You’ll find what you’re looking for,” Marty said, with so much conviction Billy couldn’t help but be temporarily convinced. He continued staring at the bits and pieces Marty had taped to his walls. There were maps of other areas around town, each marked and divided into searchable sections. He’d made list upon list of places. There was one labeled “Jennie’s favorite hangouts” and another of nearby towns. Another listed homeless shelters.

From the newspaper articles, Billy saw that it’d been over a year since Marty’s daughter had gone missing—around the same time Billy’s father had left. A year and Marty was still looking for a daughter Billy didn’t think was ever coming home.

“I gotta pee. The phone is over there on the table if you want to make your call. I’ll be right back.” Marty left and opened a door at the back of the trailer, tucked himself inside, and promptly slammed the door shut. He hummed a tune alongside the soft trickle of relieving himself into the bowl.

Billy didn’t wait for him to finish. He went to the phone to call his mother, but the phone went to a busy signal. He didn’t try another time, instead leaving the trailer and running until he was by himself in the woods once again, only now the once golden sun was dwindling over the horizon.



Billy was tired and sweating and still hadn’t found the leopard. Earlier, he thought he’d found its tracks. But somewhere along the way he’d lost the trail and he wasn’t sure anymore if he’d imagined it. It was getting dark, and he still had no idea where he was. His adventure had turned out to not be what he’d hoped or expected.

In this moment, he wished he'd made up the leopard. If it'd been just a story, then he could have chosen not to believe in it and he wouldn't be out here, alone and afraid. But he had seen it, he couldn't take that back. It had been there in his window, its large eyes beckoning to him.

Not knowing where he was going, he began walking through the woods. He picked up his pace, thinking the faster he went, the sooner he'd get to something he'd recognized. He ran until something caught on his foot and he tripped.

There in the dirt was a cat, black and lying on the ground. It was clear the cat had given birth, the act of which must have killed her. The fetus was next to the mother, both their bodies beginning to stench up the air.

Billy stared down at the mother. The cat appeared smaller to him now, on the ground in front of him, and for a moment he wasn't sure if this was the same animal he'd seen days before slinking by his window. He crouched low, pressed his hand against her fur and waited for a heartbeat.

He'd never seen death before, not up close like this. On television once, he'd watched a special about elephants and how they'd mourn the loss of those not even from their herd. They performed the same ritual for them as they would their own, spending days periodically going to pick leaves and dirt to bury the dead.

He reached down to pick up the baby, its fur slick with a mixture of blood and fluid. The eyes were slits, and he was glad for this, for not having being able to look into its eyes.

He used his hands to dig a hole in the dirt. He couldn't bury the mother, just the baby, but he felt it was enough. When he finished, he used the last of his energy to drag the mother's body into nearby bushes. He broke off some tree branches until the cat was covered. No one would find her here, he thought. She'd rest in peace.

By the time Billy got home, his mother was waiting on the front porch. She looked as if she'd been standing there since he left. Her makeup had settled into the cracks of her skin. Her blouse was untucked, the hem draping over the front of her skirt. One of her shoes was lying on the next step below her. She hadn't noticed him at first, instead focusing her bleary gaze down the street in the other direction. When she turned and saw her son, covered in dirt and blood, she broke down and cried.

"Honey," she said. "I've been looking everywhere. I didn't know what else to do."

Billy collapsed on the porch step. Glancing at their front yard, he saw weeds had sprung up all around, even in the cracks in their sidewalk and driveway. The hedges framing the porch were in need of a trim. His gaze went across the street to Mrs. Keeler's. Her gutters were filled with leaves, as they'd been for weeks, since the heart attack of her husband. At the house next door, the Sullins girl was having a fight with her father. Billy watched her storm out the house, yelling as she got in her car and lit a cigarette. He looked at other houses and noticed what he hadn't before—fences with chipped paint, bushes overgrown, forlorn toys scattered across the lawns. Everywhere, there seemed a bit of brokenness, a dim amidst the glimmer of curated perfection.

"I thought I could catch it."

"Catch what?"

"The leopard," Billy said. "I saw it the other night and tried to tell you. I thought if I could catch it, you'd believe me when I said it was real."

"Oh, I believe you. I've always believed you," she said, and Billy didn't argue. He knew he'd never have proof and that the leopard would never be caught. The rumors would continue, growing with the retelling, until no one would be left to remember if there was ever any truth at all.

Billy let his mother hug him, pulling him closer so that he couldn't smell the blood on his clothes or the cooked grease from hers, instead smelling the lingering magnolia scent of her hair. He wanted to tell her he knew the truth—that his father was never coming back, that this new world they were living in was because of him.

“It’s going to be all right,” she said, and Billy didn’t tell her he knew otherwise. After all, he did have her. So maybe it was okay if he let his mother pretend, he thought. At least for a little while longer.